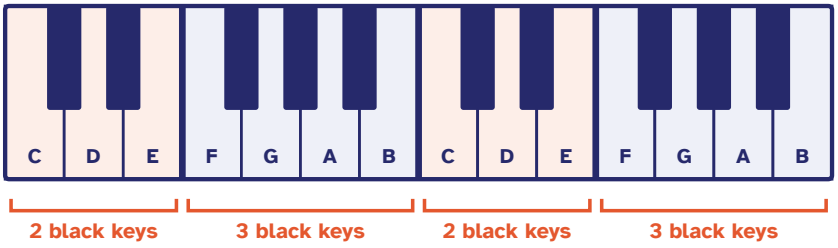
PART I · PITCH · 1

The keyboard

Keys to the **left** sound **lower**; keys to the **right** sound **higher**. The black keys come in groups of **two** and **three**, and that pattern repeats all the way along: it is how you find every note.

THE SECRET

Find the two black keys: C is always just to their left.



The white keys

Seven letters, **A B C D E F G**, then the letters start again, like the days of the week. **C D E** sit around each group of two black keys (C just left of it), **F G A B** around each group of three (F just left of it): the two tints on the picture.

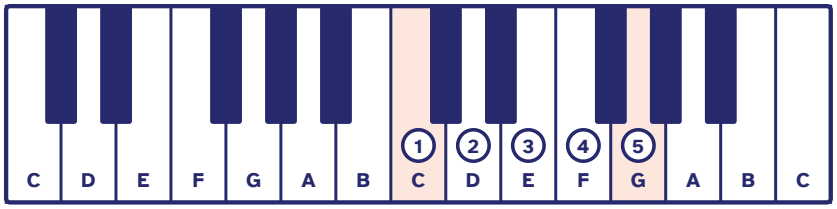
Middle C and octaves

Middle C is the C nearest the middle of the keyboard. From one C to the next is an **octave**: eight white keys, counting both. Octaves are numbered from the bottom: middle C is **C4**, the C below it C3, the C above C5; every key up to the next B shares the number (D4, E4 … B4).

TERM	MEANING	FIRST MET
pitch	how high or low a sound is	Level 0
register	a part of the keyboard: low, middle or high	Level 0
semitone	from one key to the very next key, black or white	Level 0
tone	two semitones	Level 0
octave	from one note to the next with the same name (8 white keys, 12 semitones)	Level 0

EXAMPLE 1

Find G4 on the keyboard



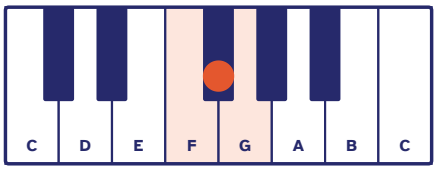
1. **Find middle C (C4):** the C just left of the two black keys nearest the middle.
2. **Count up the letters**, one white key each: C D E F G is five keys.
3. **Same octave**, so the number stays 4.

The key: **G4**. One octave higher, the next G, is G5.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Find F♯4

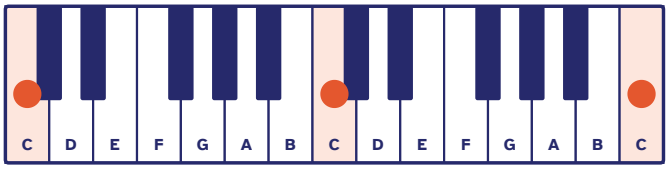


1. **Find F4:** the white key just left of the group of three black keys above middle C.
2. **Sharp means up:** move one key to the right.
3. **The very next key** is black: that is F♯.

F♯4 is the **black key** just right of F4, the first of the group of three.

EXAMPLE 3

Find C3, C4 and C5

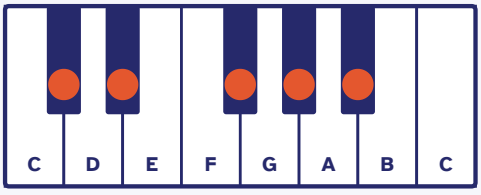


1. **Find middle C (C4):** just left of the two black keys in the middle.
2. **Count seven white keys down:** C3.
3. **Count seven white keys up:** C5.

Every C sits just left of a group of **two** black keys, an octave apart.

YOU KNOW THIS

Amazing Grace, on the black keys only



The whole tune fits on the **five black keys**: D♭ G♭ B♭ G♭ B♭ A♭ G♭ E♭ D♭. The groups of two and three are a little melody machine.

Try it. Start on the lower key of a pair of black keys and find the tune by ear.

THINK OF IT The black keys are like the little bumps on F and J of a computer keyboard: feel them and you know where you are without looking.

TRAP

- × Counting octaves from the left end of the piano: octave numbers always change at C, not A.
- × Calling every black key a sharp: each one has a flat name too (p. 30).

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 24 · The staff and the keyboard p. 28

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 1 · Online: Library › Keyboard